

Making a profile people pick

7 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

The photo decides most of it, not the wording. Listing accomplishments backfires, and the boxes you tick, like religion or habits, barely move how appealing the profile looks.

THE GOAL

You're putting your effort where it actually changes whether someone taps. Gather three or four other photos and ask a couple of people which one they'd pick.

CHECKLIST

Opening your profile to make another change after a stretch with no matches.

- ☐ Look at the photo that's set as your main one right now.
- ☐ Gather three or four other photos you could use instead, not just your usual favourites.
- ☐ Send those photos to two or three people who know you and ask which one they'd pick, without saying which one you'd choose.
- ☐ If two or more agree, **set that photo as your main one** now.
- ☐ If everyone disagrees, use the one that got the most confident yes, not your own favourite.
- ☐ Swap out any other photo where your face is hard to make out, like a distant group shot or one with sunglasses on.
- ☐ Skim the checkbox fields, like religion or habits, filling in only what's true, and don't spend more than a minute there.
- ☐ Read your bio out loud once. If it says only one thing about you, or nothing, add one concrete detail.
- ☐ If your bio lists jobs, degrees or achievements back to back, **cut that part** for one specific thing you actually do or care about.
- ☐ Save the profile, then close the app without rereading it.
- ☐ Write down today's date and which photo you set as the main one.
- ☐ Set a reminder for two weeks from now to check your match count before changing anything else.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 You list your accomplishments to sound impressive, but it backfires.
- 2 The boxes you tick, like religion or habits, barely affect how appealing your profile looks.
- 3 Feeling insecure about a quiet inbox is common, **not proof something's wrong with you**.

The words you keep rewriting

DON'T

You list your accomplishments to sound impressive, but it backfires.

People who lean on self-promotion come across as **less likeable**, the opposite of what they wanted. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

A bio that says almost nothing still sends a message. In a set of studies, sparse bios came across as less socially appealing and led people to assume you mainly wanted something casual.

So swap a blank box for a specific, real detail instead of assuming the photo covers for it. [Source 2](#)

What's deciding this

KNOW

The boxes you tick, like religion or habits, barely affect how appealing your profile looks.

Only what you wrote yourself in your own words moved that rating in the study, so answer the boxes quickly. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

The photo is doing almost all the deciding, not the bio you keep rewriting. A stronger picture beat a better bio, job title or intelligence score by a wide margin in a study, so that's where your next hour should go.

The study built matched profiles differing only in the photo, the bio, the job and the IQ score, then had people choose. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Getting picked and being liked run on different tracks. A study on profile photos measured only the split-second swipe choice, separate from what keeps someone engaged once you're talking.

A photo opens the door, and what happens in conversation afterward is a separate skill it can't do for you. [Source 4](#)

Trusting your own read on this

KNOW

You're a bad judge of your own photo. People pick **less flattering photos of themselves** than strangers do.

Ask a few people you trust to pick independently, and go with whichever photo they agree on. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

Feeling insecure about a quiet inbox is common, **not proof something's wrong with you.**

In a national survey, men were about as likely to feel insecure about their message count as women were to feel swamped by too many. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Dating bios have an ideal length, something like a couple of short paragraphs, and hitting that range makes the bio work.

ACTUALLY

How long your bio runs doesn't decide how appealing it reads. In the study that tested this directly, the attractiveness ratings people gave the written part **had no relationship to how many words it ran**, only to what was said. [Source 3](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.cmu.edu/news/stories/archives/2015/may/bragging-researchers-find-self-promotion-often-backfires.html>
2. <https://studyfinds.com/what-makes-dating-bio-work/>
3. <https://people.ischool.berkeley.edu/~hearst/papers/chi2008.pdf>
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5. <https://www.unsw.edu.au/newsroom/news/2017/04/why-you-should-get-a-stranger-to-choose-your-profile-pictures>
6. <https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/2023/02/02/the-experiences-of-u-s-online-daters/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Dating and first dates at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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